

ROP FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

What is Reduced Oxygen Packaging (ROP)?

It is a packaging method in which the internal environment of the package contains less than normal levels of oxygen such as vacuum packaging, sous vide cooking, and cook-chill packaging.

What is needed if I want to do ROP in my establishment?

A HACCP plan outlining specific procedures and temperature monitoring to minimize risks for reduced oxygen packaging TCS (Time/Temperature Control for Safety) foods must be submitted for review and approved by the Division.

You may write your own HACCP plan or use a HACCP plan template provided by the Division at: [Hotels & Restaurants – Special Process – MyFloridaLicense.com](https://myfloridalicense.com/hotels-restaurants-special-process)

What TCS foods are allowed to be packaged in ROP?

- The following foods can be vacuum packaged: raw foods such as meat, poultry and vegetables; meats and poultry products cured with nitrites/nitrates in a USDA regulated facility; and commercially manufactured hard and semi-soft cheese (no ingredients added by the establishment)
- Raw fish/seafood can be vacuum packaged ONLY if frozen before, during and after packaging. Frozen fish/seafood would need to be fully removed from the package before thawing
- Raw foods (except fish/seafood) can be sous vide packaged. Raw food is vacuum packaged, cooked in the sealed bag, rapidly chilled, and held refrigerated or frozen for later use
- Fully cooked food (except fish/seafood) can be cook-chill packaged. Cooked food is hot filled in an impermeable bag and sealed while 135°F or above, chilled in the sealed bag, and held refrigerated or frozen for later use

Are there any exceptions when a HACCP plan is not required for ROP?

A HACCP plan is not required if the TCS food in ROP is always:

- Labeled with production date and time
- Held at 41°F or below during refrigerated storage
- Removed from the ROP in the establishment within 48 hours of packaging (even if stored frozen)
- This exception applies to raw or cooked TCS foods (no fish/seafood)

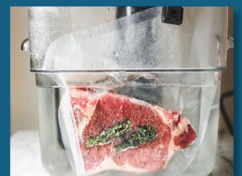
Important: ROP methods that deviate from the above or other FDA Food Code requirements will need a Process Waiver approved by the Division.

Email questions: DHR.SpecialProcess@myfloridalicense.com

CAUTION

ROP increases the risk of a food-borne illness from *Clostridium botulinum* and *Listeria monocytogenes*

FDA Food Code Reference 3-502.12



Please contact your DBPR inspector before conducting ROP or a special process